

Day 2 — The Four Vedas

Module: What is IKS? (Middle) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students name the four Vedas, distinguish the four textual layers within each Veda, and identify what counts as “Vedic intellectual contribution” beyond ritual.

Materials

- Wall chart: 4 Vedas × 4 layers grid
- Printed extract: Ṛg Veda 1.1 (Agni hymn) with translation

Vocabulary

- *Samhitā* — “collection”; the hymn layer
- *Brāhmaṇa* — ritual commentaries
- *Āraṇyaka* — “forest texts”; intermediate philosophical
- *Upaniṣad* — “sitting near”; philosophical dialogues

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Daily prompt — 2 students share.

Core (20 min)

1. The Four Vedas (write on board):

Veda	Focus
<i>Ṛg Veda</i>	Hymns of praise (~1500–1200 BCE)
<i>Yajur Veda</i>	Ritual formulas
<i>Sāma Veda</i>	Chants set to melody
<i>Atharva Veda</i>	Spells, incantations, early medical

2. Four layers within each Veda:

Samhitā (hymns)
↓
Brāhmaṇa (ritual commentary)
↓
Āraṇyaka (intermediate philosophy)
↓
Upaniṣad (philosophical dialogues – “Vedānta” = “end of the Vedas”)

3. The intellectual contributions (write on board):

- **Sanskrit phonetics & grammar** — the Vedas demanded precise oral transmission, generating sophisticated linguistic analysis (peaking in Pāṇini, ~4th c. BCE).
 - **Early astronomy** — calendar calculation embedded in ritual texts.
 - **Atharva Veda medicine** — the earliest documented Indian medical material; Ayurveda’s roots.
 - **Upanishadic philosophy** — abstract metaphysical inquiry (later picked up by Sāṅkhya, Vedānta, etc.).
4. **Read aloud:** opening of *R̥g Veda 1.1* (the Agni hymn) — 4 lines in Sanskrit + English.
- Note: hymn form, ritual purpose, also a window into 1500 BCE worldview.

Activity (15 min) — Layer mapping

Students draw their own version of the “4 Vedas × 4 layers” grid in their notebook. For each cell, they write one one-line description.

Then they pick ONE cell and write a 1-sentence answer to: “*What might someone studying THIS layer be trying to understand?*”

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Quick exit ticket (oral): “Name one Veda and one layer.”
- Preview Day 3: “*Tomorrow — the Vedangas, six auxiliary disciplines that grew up around the Vedas.*”

Student-facing content

The Four Vedas

Veda	What it contains
R̥g	Hymns of praise (~1500–1200 BCE)
Yajur	Ritual formulas
Sāma	Chants and melody
Atharva	Spells, early medicine

Each Veda has FOUR layers: **Samhitā** (hymns) → **Brāhmaṇa** (ritual commentary) → **Āraṇyaka** (forest texts) → **Upaniṣad** (philosophical dialogues).

The *intellectual* contributions of the Veda include: Sanskrit grammar, early astronomy, early medicine, and Upanishadic philosophy.

Homework

- Find ONE Upaniṣad name (e.g. Īśa, Kena, Kaṭha, Praśna, Muṇḍaka, Māṇḍūkya — there are 108 traditionally, with 13 considered “principal”). Bring tomorrow.

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read the Īśa Upaniṣad in translation (it's 18 verses; the shortest principal Upaniṣad).
- **Tier down:** Just remember the four Vedas + the four layers.

Teacher notes

- The dating “~1500–1200 BCE” for the Ṛg Veda is the mainstream scholarly view (Indo-European migration model). Some Indian scholars argue for earlier dates. Acknowledge both; this isn't the module to resolve the debate.
- The four-Veda framing is itself a classification. Some Vedic texts don't fit cleanly. The grid is a useful first map, not the final word.

Citation(s) used

- Ṛg Veda 1.1 — Jamison & Brereton (2014) translation.
- Pollock (2006) on Vedic transmission and linguistic precision.